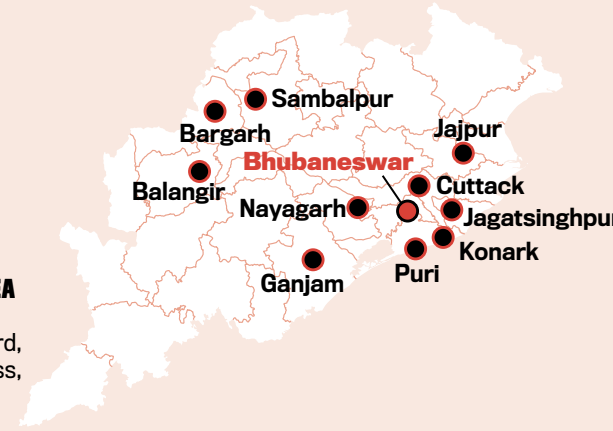


THE HERITAGE PROJECTS

Renovation or beautification programmes are under way for the following temples and heritage sites in Odisha



1) JAGANNATH TEMPLE, PURI
Shree Mandir Parikrama Project (SMPP): Increasing open space from 5 acres to 26 acres (75 m corridor with 7 m green buffer zone, 10 m pradakshina, 14 m landscape, 8 m outer pradakshina, 10 m public convenience zone, 4.5 m service lane, 4.5 m shuttle emergency lane, 7.5 mixed traffic and 7 m footpath)
Cost: Rs 800 crore

2) LINGARAJ TEMPLE, BHUBANESWAR
Ekamra Conservation Plan covers Lingaraj, Mukteshwar and Ananta Vasudev temples; renovation of water bodies and encircling corridors
Cost: Rs 120-130 crore

3) KONARK HERITAGE AREA BEAUTIFICATION
Foot overbridge, boulevard, shuttle lane, temple access, VIP amenities
Cost: Rs 140-150 crore

4) GUNDICHA TEMPLE, PURI

5) NEELA MADHABA TEMPLE, NAYAGARH
Road widening, temple precinct development, beautification and public amenities, pond development
Cost: Rs 70 crore

6) MA SAMALESHWARI TEMPLE, SAMBALPUR
Cost: Rs 110 crore

7) MA BIRAJA TEMPLE, JAJPUR

8) MA CHANDI TEMPLE, CUTTACK
Improvement of temple complex; amenities for pilgrims and priests; rehabilitation of shopkeepers and hawkers; external drainage
Cost: Rs 60 crore

9) MA TARA TARINI TEMPLE, GANJAM

10) HARI SHANKAR TEMPLE, BALANGIR

11) NRUSINGHANATH TEMPLE, BARGARH

12) MA SARALA TEMPLE, JAGATSINGHPUR
Cost: Rs 40 crore

13) HERITAGE CREMATORIUM, SWARGODWAR, PURI
Cost: Rs 6 crore

cally appealing, accessible and secured environment". From the outlay, Rs 800 crore was earmarked for SMPP—to build a 75-metre-wide corridor around the Jagannath Temple, which would have landscape gardening, resting places, drinking water facilities, toilets and other amenities for pilgrims. The SMPP was aimed at freeing the pathway leading to the temple from all kinds of encumbrances and to provide pilgrims a passage to walk around the temple.

In addition, Rs 190 crore was set aside to build a Jagannath Ballav Pilgrim Centre over five acres of land with facilities like meditation space, and another Rs 685 crore for development of monasteries, restoration of religious and heritage lakes, laying of a garden (Pramod Udyan) and heritage roads connecting Jagannath Temple with Gundicha Temple and Gurukula project, besides a multi-level parking lot.

According to Binayak Dasamahapatra, a priest at Jagannath Temple, the planned corridor draws its inspiration from the Kashi Vishwanath temple corridor in Varanasi. However, unlike in Varanasi, where all institutions of the Centre and the state got together to implement Prime Minister Narendra Modi's dream project, despite some opposition from locals, the SMPP is caught in a typical Centre-state standoff. "Here, people are in favour of the project, but BJP leaders seem to have a problem," says Dasamahapatra.

A PRIEST AT JAGANNATH TEMPLE SAYS THE PLANNED CORRIDOR DRAWS ITS INSPIRATION FROM THE KASHI VISHWANATH TEMPLE CORRIDOR IN VARANASI

While BJP members seem reluctant to make statements on the issue, the party's state spokesperson Biranchi Tripathi says "the temple's security is our prime concern". He complains that engineers have allowed drilling 20-30 ft for the pillars, in gross violation of the Ancient Monuments and Archaeological Sites and Remains Act.

Coming in handy for the state government to justify the project were the observations of a judicial committee headed by retired Justice B.P. Das, set up in 2016 to look into aspects of temple governance and endowments. The committee had asked for urgent measures to enhance security at the temple, which saw an average daily footfall of 50,000 people, going up to 1 million during the annual Rath Yatra. Moreover, the reckless growth of shops, hotels and other commercial buildings had ended up hiding the temple's 16-feet-high heritage boundary wall—the Meghanad Pacheri—from view. The 100-metre-wide pathway around the temple had